

DAY 15: REDUCE YOUR PHONE BILL

Between landlines and smartphones, the average user is connected 24/7, with a cell sitting no more than a few feet away. Long distance isn't so much of a problem anymore, and minutes are mostly a thing of the past. And yet, we pay more than ever to have access to this technology!

Every day, I realize just how much more I can't live without this mini computer in my purse or back pocket. It's not only my instant connection to the outside world; it's also necessary for me to stay on top of my job. Plus, it's so convenient—the availability of data to access the internet, the convenience of texting over calling, and practically unlimited everything has spoiled me into never ever giving it up.

Still, I hate paying those astronomical prices, and I know most other phone owners do too. A personal or family phone plan usually makes up a significant portion of the budget, not to mention those nasty fees when a teen or two go over their monthly limit.

Thankfully, the phone market has shifted drastically over the past few years, with major players dropping two-year contract requirements, and smaller companies rising up with more affordable price points. Honestly, there's no better time than now to negotiate and lower your monthly phone bill, without getting rid of all the conveniences you've come to rely on and love.

Sure, you might have to sacrifice here and there—I'm still working on how much data I can live without—but more competition and more options mean there are also more ways to lower that bill. Here are my six favorite ways to cut back:

1. DITCH THE LANDLINE

If you still have a landline, first consider how often you really use it. Besides the excess sales calls, does it really warrant the addition of an entirely new phone contract and bill? Well, it depends.